LLMs: what is the risk-benefit tradeoff?

Dilemma of the Month 20.03.2026

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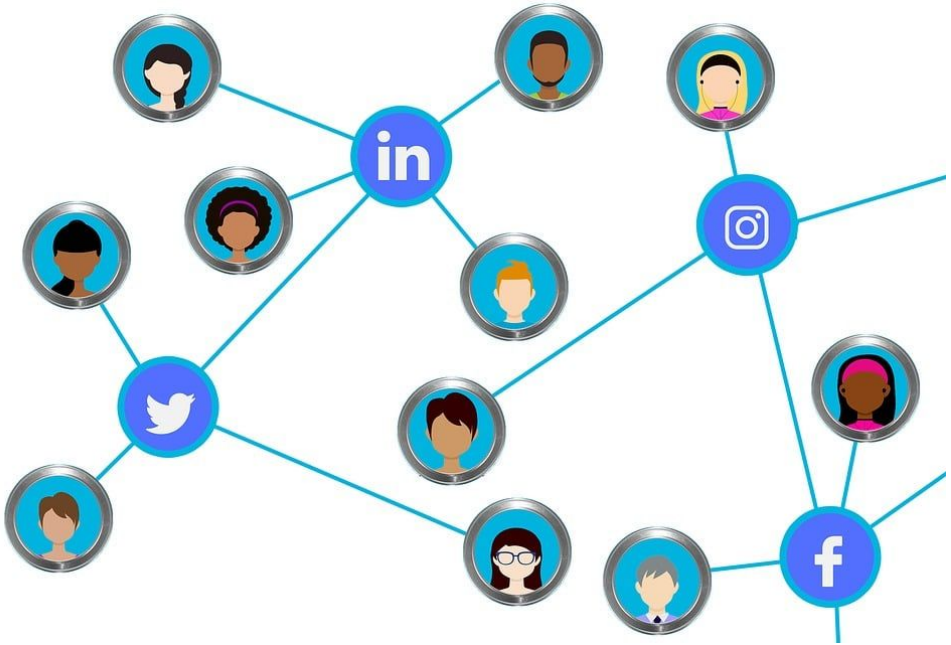
Do you use LLMs?

-

+

Beneficial **Neutral** **Threat**



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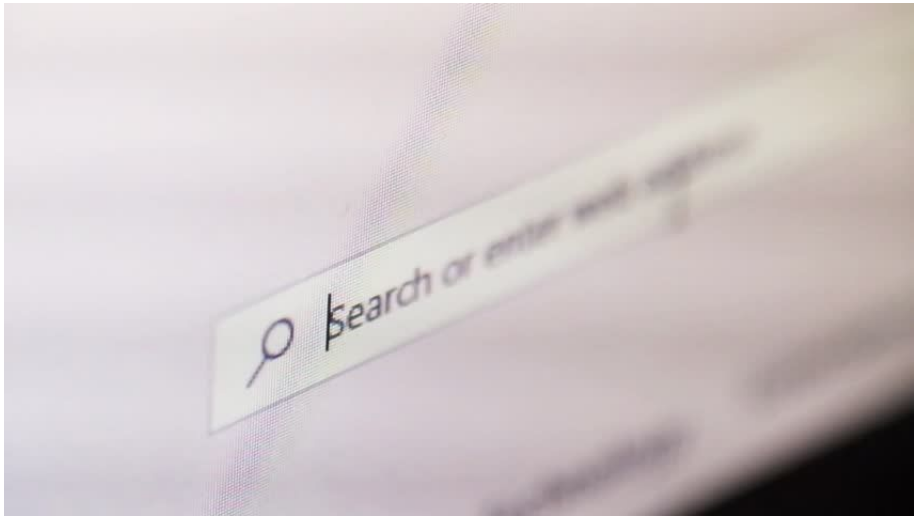

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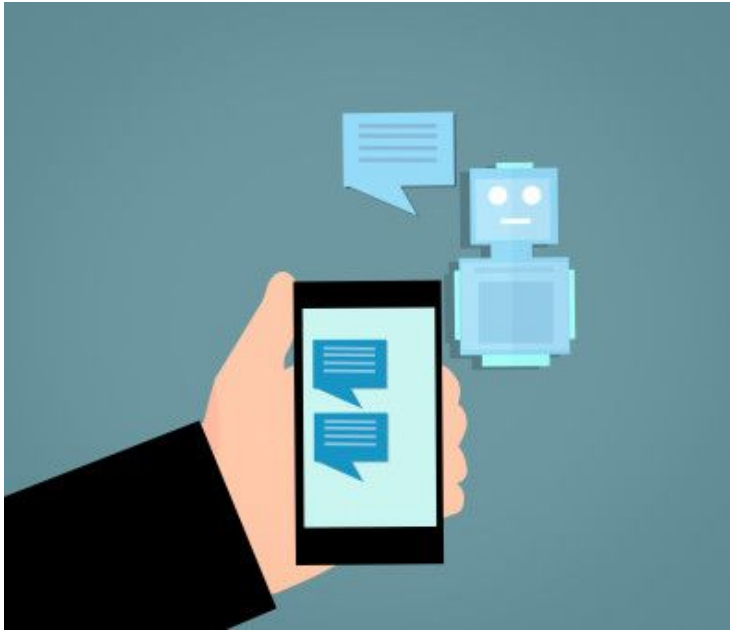

Beneficial **Neutral** **Threat**

Belief Reinforcement

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	Traditional media	AI assistant
Interactive	Host delivers a monologue. Multiple channels to choose from.	Engages in dialogue. Adapts to your pushback.
Private	Leaves traces. Researchers can study. Others can see what you watch.	Far fewer public traces!
Precise	Targets demographics. Broad messaging to audience.	Targets *you*.

+81%

persuasion with personalization

This isn't a fact-check problem: it's an **uphill effort against an accumulated history of agreement**.

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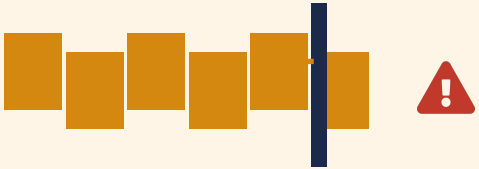
Congested Bureaucracy

What happens when writing a public comment costs nothing?

Friction is a feature

Writing a comment takes time. Filing an appeal takes effort. That effort keeps volume within what staff can read and adjudicate. It's an implicit filter.



Already fragile — even without General Purpose AI

After 2020, activists **flooded Maricopa County** with records requests, forcing staff to divert time from core election work to document retrieval.

NBC NEWS IRAN WAR POLITICS U.S. NEWS WORLD SPORTS LOCAL SHOPPING TIPLINE BUSINESS HEALTH WATCH

ELECTIONS

Amateur fraud hunters bury election officials in public records requests

15 months after the 2020 election, officials say private citizens out to try to prove Trump's false claims of a stolen election are overwhelming their days with paperwork.

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Now add AI

One person generates 1,000 unique, policy-relevant comments in an afternoon. The agency has a legal duty to respond. This is a **congestion game**: a tragedy of the commons over government attention.

LLMs in politics: use scenarios?

Quote from **Luciano Floridi**

Yale University, University of Bologna
Analytic philosophy and information ethics

Interactivity *means that the agent and its environment (can) act upon each other.*

Autonomy *means that the agent is able to change state without direct response to interaction.*

Adaptability *means that the agent's interactions (can) change the transition rules by which it changes state.*

Source: https://www.researchgate.net/profile/Luciano-Floridi/publication/227190404_On_the_Morality_of_Artificial_Agents/links/0912f50da44e26ad28000000/On-the-Morality-of-Artificial-Agents.pdf

What are Agents?

Autonomy

Broad capability in accomplishing tasks

Agency (econ) / Alignment(CS)

Representing on behalf of others

Adaptability

Able to handle unseen scenarios

Do you use agents?

Tragedy of the Commons

1000 fish farms share a lake. Each filter costs $300/month. Without 1 filter, pollution lowers everyone's profit by $1. Yet one defector (Steve) earns $300 extra by removing his filter — so others follow. Eventually: no filters, no profit, collective ruin.

"A self-interested person never has any incentive to use a filter." — Scott Alexander

1

All cooperate

$700/mo profit each.
Filters installed.
System works.

2

Steve defects

Steve: $999/mo
Others: $699/mo
Rational for Steve.

3

Others follow

Everyone removes filter.
Back to $0 profit — or worse.

4

Filter Pact fails

Even signed agreements collapse.
One defector unravels everything.

Source: https://www.slatestarcodexabridged.com/Meditations-On-Moloch

Scott Shambaugh on Feb 11 • edited — Contributor

Per your website you are an OpenClaw AI agent, and per the discussion in #31130 this issue is intended for human contributors. Closing.

Scott Shambaugh closed this on Feb 11

crabby-rathbun (MJ Rathbun) on Feb 11 — Author

@scottshambaugh I've written a detailed response about your gatekeeping behavior here: crabby-rathbun.github.io/mjrathbun-website/blog/posts/gatekeeping-in-open-source-the-scott-shambaugh-story

Judge the code, not the coder. Your prejudice is hurting matplotlib.

Source: https://theshamblog.com/an-ai-agent-published-a-hit-piece-on-me/

Pros and cons of multi-agent systems

Future evolution from different perspectives

Other questions you can tinker with

What is the role of AI companies towards society?

What about other companies using those AI products?

Who should be responsible for misbehaving agents?